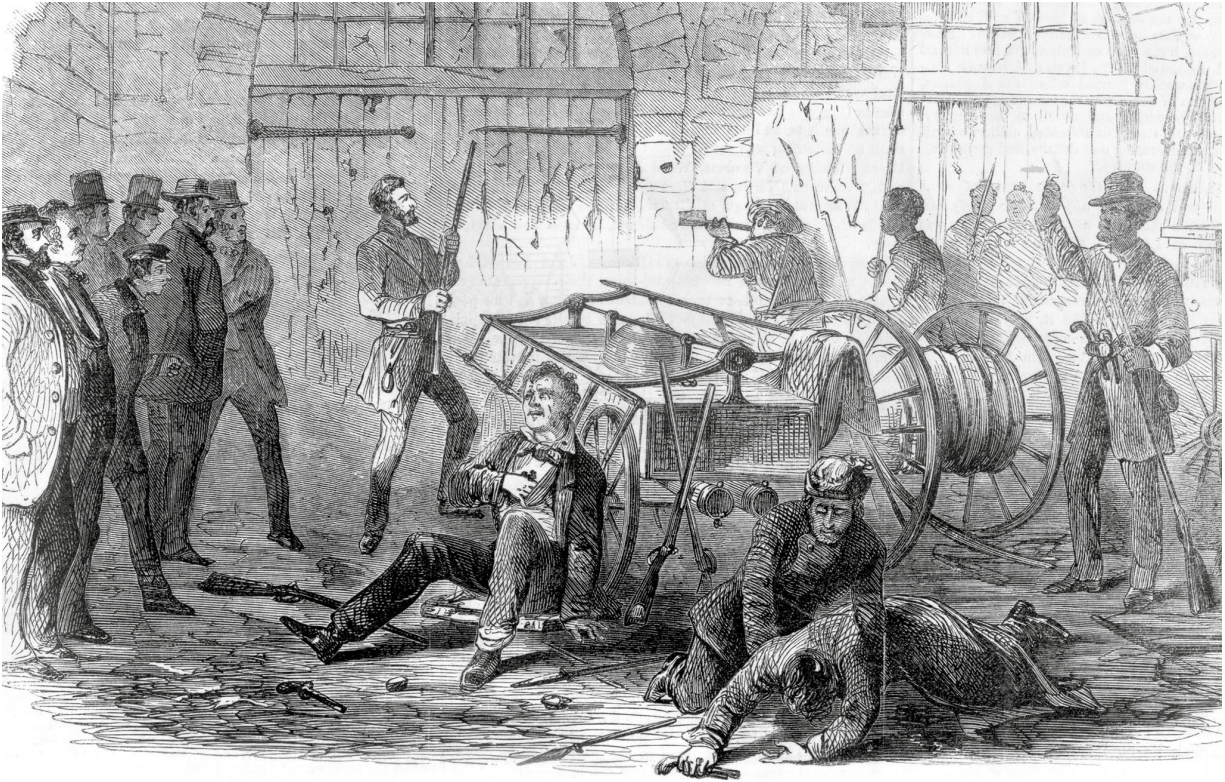




Inside the engine house

This engraving in a contemporary newspaper imagines the scene inside the engine house just before the Marines broke down the door. The hostages taken by Brown are standing on the left.

Abolitionist roots

Born in Connecticut in 1800, Brown as a youth and adult moved regularly, usually after one of his many business failures. His deeply religious parents instilled in him a hatred of slavery that led to an early involvement in abolition. He served as a member of the “Underground Railroad” and lived for two years in a freedman’s community. By the age of 50, Brown saw himself as ordained by God to avenge the evils of slavery.

In August 1855, he joined five of his sons in Kansas to fight against the pro-slavery faction there. Following the reports of the “sack” of Lawrence, Kansas, Brown sought vengeance. He led six men, including four of his sons, to the homes of pro-slavery families living near Pottawatomie Creek and hacked the men and older boys to death with broadswords. In another incident at Osawatomie, he and his men killed a large number of pro-slavery raiders from